The Forsyth County News

Opinion

This is a page of opinions – ours, yours and others. Signed columns and cartoons are the opinions of the writers and artists and may not reflect our views.

When tragedy involves the loss of a child, too many questions remain

Why? It's a difficult question with few consoling answers. Why does a child have to die? And, why so tragic and brutal a death?

No response can ease the pain of the loss felt by the family, by friends, by schoolmates and teachers of Levi Frady, who is to be laid to rest Sunday. No justification can be found for the senseless murder of a child less than a dozen years old. There should have been so much living ahead for the sixth grader.

And the "what if" questions also loom. What if he hadn't had ridden away on his bike, which was found in a ditch near his home? What if it hadn't been a school night and what if he hadn't had homework to do which apparently took him to a friend's house?

Authorities know a gunshot blast killed the child, but details which have been released are sketchy. Who could have perpetrated such a crime against the bright-eyed youngster? Who would commit such a heinous act – killing and leaving the 11-year-old in the woods?

Whoever is found to be connected to the murder, there is one thing that no one will ever be able to answer to the satisfaction of the family – and the community. Why?

Pedestrians, motorists urged to take care this Halloween

With all the ghosts and goblins roaming the streets, the Georgia Coalition for Vehicle Choice wants to remind motorists, parents and trick-or-treaters to do their part to make this Halloween safe and fun for everyone.

With the majority of trick-or-treaters being out after dark and many wearing dark costumes, it makes it harder for motorists to see them. "Youngsters should wear light or reflective costumes, and should be urged to take their masks off when running from house to house – any kind of mask can make it harder for them to see," said CVC associate coordinator Kathryn Mitchell.

Pedestrian deaths accounted for more than 13 percent of traffic fatalities in the U. S. last year, according to the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration. Last year, 35 persons were injured fatally in traffic-related incidents on Halloween night – and 20 were pedestrians.

To avoid having your child or loved one become a statistic, CVC recommends these tips to make Halloween night a safe one for all pedestrians:

It's always better to travel in a group – besides, it's often times much more fun. Cross the street only at intersections and not in mid-block. Wear bright clothing – something that makes you visible to those passing by.

• Carry a flashlight – it will help you see better and make you more visible to motorists.

• Follow well-traveled paths and away from allays and shortcuts between neighborhoods. Make sure you look both ways before crossing a street or road.

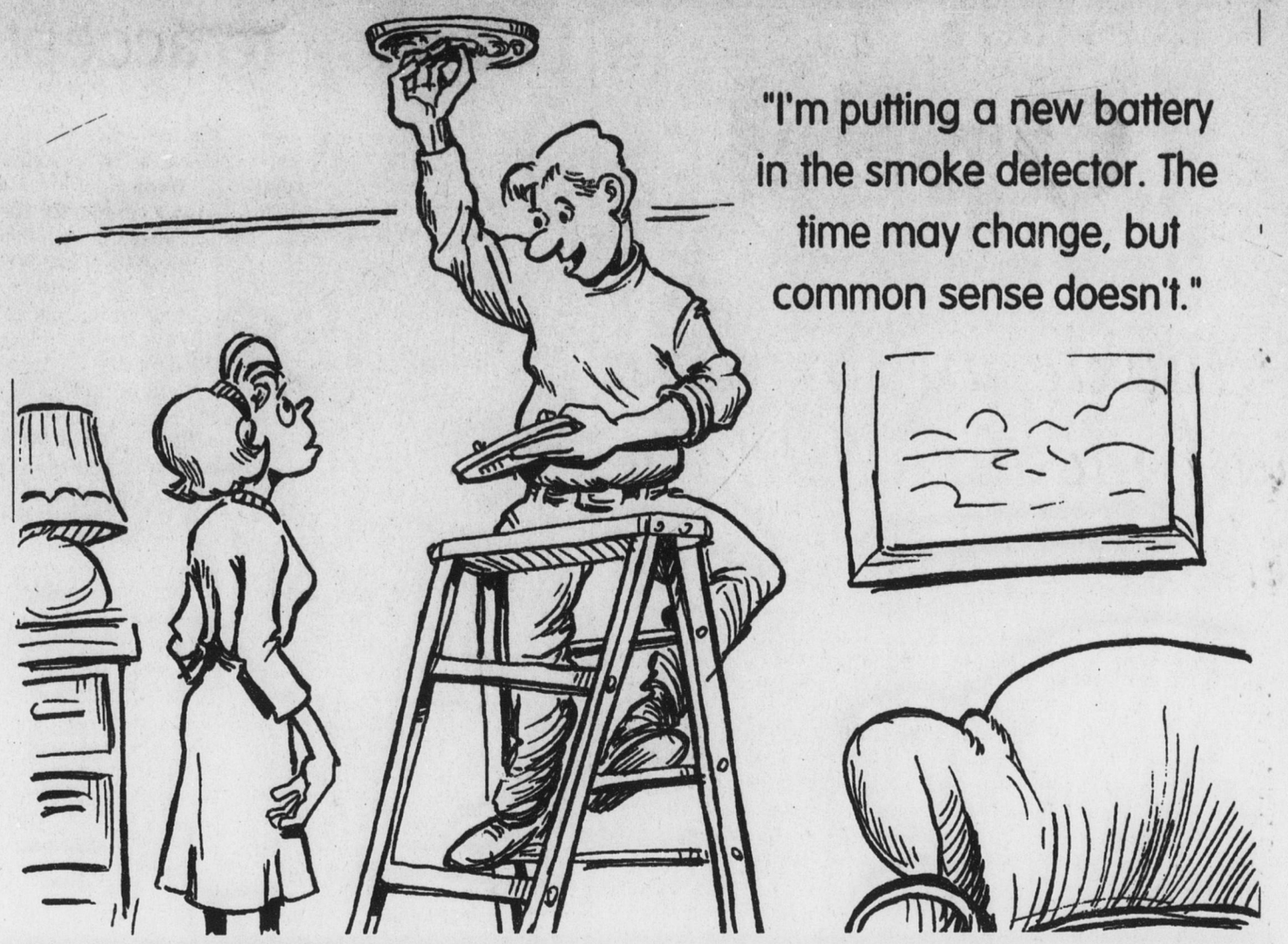
In addition to these tips for trick-or-treaters on foot, Mitchell also reminds motorists to:

• Watch your speed through neighborhoods and side streets.

• Look out for children darting out from behind cars.

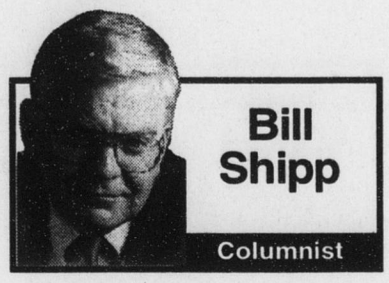
And for those older trick-or-treaters, have a designated driver. Not only are there four times more children out on Halloween, there are also more police officers looking for any kind of mischief, as well as intoxicated drivers. Also remember to remove any kind of mask before driving.

By following these tips, you can help make Halloween both safe and fun for everyone young and old," Mitchell said.



"I'm putting a new battery in the smoke detector. The time may change, but common sense doesn't."

Have the 'two Georgias' swapped places?



Bill Shipp
Columnist

The "two Georgias" are not what they used to be. You may remember those two theoretical regions from the 1980s.

University professors and economists decided a decade or so ago that the state of Georgia was not simply one jurisdiction but two distinct areas, divided geographically and economically. The two Georgias became a topic of a half-dozen important studies.

Georgia No. 1 was mostly Atlanta and environs. It wore the twin badges of growth and prosperity. Optimism abounded in Georgia No. 1. When you thought of the affluence of the New South, you thought of the gleaming towers of Atlanta and its immediate suburbs.

Georgia No. 2 was non-Atlanta Georgia. It lagged economically, and many of its leaders were pessimistic about its future. Poverty and stagnation were its main characteristics.

Fast forward a decade, and look what has happened.

Georgia No. 1 is growing so fast that parts of it have become unmanageable. Crime in the capital city, the heart of Georgia No. 1, is off the charts. Atlanta leads the nation in quantifiable violence, according to the latest Department of Justice figures.

Dirty air and untreated sewage threaten to stifle future growth. In 1999 the federal government will impose a moratorium on highway building in the Atlanta area if the region fails to meet clean air standards.

Middle-class families, black and white, have fled the city to live in the suburbs. The cost and chaos of city living were too much to bear. Taxes are higher than anywhere else in the state. Public schools are among the poorest.

Traffic in Georgia No. 1 is turning into a nightmare. Rush hour along the interstate highways in the metro region begins before dawn and ends past the dinner hour. A national traffic study rates metro Atlanta among the 10 most congested areas in the country.

The Nov. 4 Atlanta elections may be emblematic of a jurisdiction whose government has lost sight of its mission of service.

If you live in Dalton or Valdosta or Gainesville or Thomasville, you may not care what happens in Atlanta's elections. But they are worth watching closely for they may contain a lesson about what could happen anywhere when race dominates every decision and when the business community finally throws up its collective hands and despairs.

Meanwhile, Georgia No. 2 is perking along pretty well. Pockets of desperate poverty still exist in the rural reaches of the state, particularly in the southwest quadrant.

But the mountains of north Georgia and several coastal counties are booming. Growth in south Georgia has picked up, partly as a result of an overflow of Florida's population. The seemingly endless recession in Augusta has finally evaporated.

The HOPE scholarship program has contributed to growth along the state's borders with Tennessee and Alabama. Hundreds of families from those two states have moved their residences into Georgia No. 2 with the expectation of sending their children to college with lottery-financed grants.

Gov. Zell Miller, the father of the HOPE program, can justifiably take a bow for that surge in the "Other Georgia."

Miller's administration also has had an even more direct impact on the economy of Georgia No. 2.

When the governor leaves office, he will have made more industry-hunting trips overseas than any previous governor. To date, in his nearly eight years in office, Miller has participated in 17 international economic development missions — eight to Europe, five to Asia, and one each to Africa, South America, Mexico and Australia.

He has not brought back the bacon from every trip. None of his catches were as spectacular as Alabama's snagging a Mercedes plant or South Carolina netting a BMW factory.

But Miller's office says his efforts have resulted in the creation of 3,650 new jobs in Georgia (many of them in Georgia No. 2) and $3.5 billion in investments from overseas sources.

After returning from Asia last week, Miller announced Hankook Synthetics Inc. of Korea had decided to make a $1.2 billion investment in a manufacturing facility in Augusta. The plant will employ 350 people in the manufacture of synthetic fibers.

Adel, Covington, Carrollton and Cumming are among other Georgia No. 2 locations to benefit from Miller's globe-trotting.

As we approach the end of the century, the two Georgias may be on the verge of swapping places. Georgia No. 1 is struggling to cope with its past successes, some of which have turned sour. And once-impoverished Georgia No. 2 is marching toward a bright and affluent future.

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Here's what you think

What do you think?

The Georgia Department of Transportation has finalized its bicycle trail network and is urging local governments to make connecting roadways bike-friendly. Should Cumming and Forsyth County make an effort to develop bike pathways?

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Forsyth County News
P.O. Box 210
Cumming, Ga. 30028

Yes. If Forsyth County's growth potential is to be realized, all lifestyles and modes of transportation should be accommodated. It is impossible to bike on the current roads with Forsyth drivers' average speed.

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Yes, yes, yes! This is related to the quality of life her in Forsyth County. Let's put people to the top of the priority list, instead of cars, industry and "progress." I love to ride a bike, but don't do it much because of fear of being run over by a car. I've trained for and entered several triathlons and would use and appreciate better bike pathways. I'll volunteer to accomplish such.

Don Voss

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No. All you have to do is listen to and read the news to know that rapists and muggers lurk along them.

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Yes! Bicycles do not have to pass emissions tests. They are great for exercise, and fun! I like the idea.

Mary Braselton
Cumming

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Absolutely. Biking is a fun, healthy way to relax. Any age group can participate. It's relatively inexpensive and relaxing, noncompetitive and would be safe with pathways.

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I really would like to see the county government make some bike paths throughout the county. In every state we've lived in, we've been able to ride bikes on paths made on abandoned rail lines. In Maryland, one can ride nearly the length of the state.

Pat Swartz

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Yes – bicycle paths are a plus for any city. Due to the narrow roads with soft shoulders, bike paths would have to be segregated from high speed vehicles with dome type obstructions as they are in Europe. Painted white lines would not provide safety from this county's high speed traffic on curving roads. The absence of traffic enforcement in the past has permitted high-risk driving practices that will take years of enforcement to correct.

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Yes. Both bike pathways and running trails. Is it possible to develop 5-kilometer, 10-kilometer and half marathon running trails near the lake?

Paul M. Flood
Cumming

Letter

City commended for Country Fair and Festival

TO THE EDITOR:

On behalf of the Board of Directors of the Cumming-Forsyth County Chamber of Commerce, I would like to commend the City of Cumming for the 1997 Cumming Country Fair and Festival.

As a resident of Foresyth County, I can say the entire event fostered a sense of pride in representing our historical heritage for the community and for the entire county as well. The fair was a tremendous success in that a safe environment was established of the whole family. The overwhelming family turnout was created, in part, by allowing the fair to be economically feasible for all patrons. Children were able to enjoy the histocial and free venues with the ir parents and still enjoy the entgire fair without a financial strain. In addition to enjoying the lw cost of the event, the patrons were trated to a staff of operators working the venues that were genuinely accommodating.

It truly was a special feeling to see the Cumming Country Fair and Festival such a success. Overall, it was a proud hometown showcase that will surley set the tone for others to follow.

Sincerely,
Robert B. Shepherd, chairman
Cumming-Forsyth County Chamber of Commerce

Forsyth County News letter policy

The *Forsyth County News* welcomes your opinions on issues of public concern. Letters must be signed and include full address and a daytime and evening phone number for verification. Names and hometowns of letter writers will be included for publication, without exception. Telephone numbers will not be published. Letters should be limited to 350 words and may be edited or condensed. The same writer or group may only submit one letter per month for consideration. Letters must be submitted by noon Wednesday for Sunday publication. We do not publish poetry or blanket letters, and generally do not publish letters concerning consumer complaints. Unsigned or incorrectly identified letters will be withheld. Mail letters to the *Forsyth County News*, P. O. Box 210, Cumming, Ga 30028, hand deliver to 121 Dahlonega St., or fax to 889-6017.